

Cultural Traditions Around the World

Why do people celebrate, dress, and live so differently — and why does it matter?

tradition · culture · custom · heritage · ritual · festival · ceremony · diversity · identity · generation

Every country in the world has its own **culture** — its own way of celebrating, eating, dressing, and living. A **culture** is the shared set of customs, beliefs, and traditions that a group of people follow. Some traditions are hundreds or even thousands of years old, passed down from one **generation** to the next. Others are newer, but still important to the people who practise them.

A **tradition** is something a community does regularly, often to mark an important event. Weddings, for example, look very different around the world. In some cultures, the bride wears white; in others, she wears red or gold. In Japan, traditional weddings often include a Shinto **ceremony** at a shrine. In India, weddings can last several days and include colourful clothing, music, and elaborate henna designs on the hands. These customs may look different, but they all share the same purpose: celebrating love and bringing families together.

Festivals are another powerful example of cultural **diversity**. Diwali, the Hindu **festival** of lights, is celebrated with oil lamps, fireworks, and sweets. Lunar New Year, celebrated across East Asia, brings families together for large meals and red envelopes filled with money for children. Carnival in Brazil fills the streets with music, dancing, and elaborate costumes. Each **festival** reflects the history, religion, and values of the people who celebrate it.

Food is also a central part of cultural **heritage**. Many traditional dishes were created using ingredients available in a particular region, and recipes are often passed down within families. Sharing a traditional meal is one of the easiest ways to learn about another **culture** — and one of the most enjoyable.

Why does cultural **diversity** matter? Learning about other cultures helps us understand people who are different from us. It teaches respect, curiosity, and open-mindedness. At the same time, many communities work hard to protect their traditions, especially as globalisation makes the world feel more similar everywhere. Preserving cultural **identity** allows people to stay connected to their history while still being part of a modern, connected world.

■ TALKING POINTS

What is one tradition from your own culture that you think outsiders would find interesting?

Do you think globalisation is making cultures more similar? Is this a good or bad thing?

Which festival from another culture would you most like to experience? Why?